# TEN DAYS OUT

## Third draft review panel

Complete third draft | 34,644 words including front matter and headings | 27 October 2026

All ten chapters, the front note and the three-weeks-later ending were read in full. Five fresh-context reviewers completed Round 1 independently, without seeing earlier drafts, reports, diffs or one another's notes. Only then did they receive the comparison and conduct cross-talk. These are simulated editorial perspectives, not five human customers or a prediction of Amazon ratings. Full spoilers follow. The manuscript has not been edited.

**The answer to the course-correction question is now yes.** This revision changes Beth's conduct, gives both lovers accountability, establishes urgency before the final operation, and supplies a specific ordinary future. The remaining work is bounded: one tactical correction, compression of repeated explanation, consequential continuity fixes and human-reader validation. The full chair's judgment follows the independent reviews and cross-talk.

# ROUND 1 - INDEPENDENT REVIEWS

## 1. THE KU READER

**Verdict:** I would finish, give this four stars and try Book 2; Beth and the island carry me through a middle that sometimes explains its suspicions more often than it advances them.

**Rating: 4/5.**

### Three biggest strengths

1. **Beth earns her competence.** Chapter 1's bare-handed binder checks, dead reefer and discreet photographs give me a woman worth following before the story asks me to find her attractive. The same working knowledge drives the bar crossing, rejection of the landing and defeat of Doucette. Her refusal to let him drown belongs to her established identity. Cutter also feels inhabited: diesel, credit, freight, soup rounds and familiar radio voices have consequences.
2. **The attraction belongs to these two people.** The held flashlight, towel, rag and tactile deck lesson make contact specific. The Chapter 5 trauma-kit joke gives the restraint a welcome crack. Their three encounters move through reciprocal reliance, vulnerability and chosen domestic ease. Chapter 8 gives both people responsibility, and Chapter 10's Christmas conversation lets me picture them together after the emergency.
3. **The second half escalates and the ending closes the romance.** The fire, crossing, failed extraction, notebook and ferry attack produce different kinds of pressure. The climax uses equipment and geography already established. Tess does not receive instant forgiveness, Ned faces consequences, and Dane's misconduct reaches his employer. Visits, a transfer, Christmas arrangements and mutual declarations finish this couple's story before the ledger opens the next one.

### Three biggest problems

1. **I am ahead of Beth about Tess for a long time.** "Tess knew I stayed" arrives in Chapter 3; fuel, phone, log, money and emergency-management clues keep reinforcing the same answer. Chapter 6 openly acknowledges the withheld connection. I understand Beth's denial, but repeated exemptions eventually make me impatient. The emotional betrayal works better than the whodunit surprise.

2. **The romance sometimes feels supervised by paperwork.** Reporting, authorizations, consequences and who hears which call occupy a substantial amount of couple time. Even after the final encounter, "Pike hears about tonight from me" brings the institution back into the bedroom. I strongly believe the working partnership. More curiosity or teasing unrelated to protection would help the everyday relationship; this is my genre-balance preference, not an objection to accountability or consent.

3. **Repeated explanation slows forward movement.** The second detailed generator repair in Chapter 4 is my first skimming temptation. Suspect-circle recaps and operational explanations also revisit information. The Chapter 7-8 chronology is labeled clearly, but replaying the departure night briefly interrupts the momentum of Beth's walk. Dane's confession matters; some surrounding reconstruction could be leaner.

**Change first:** Replace one repeated Tess-excusing beat with a reasonable attempt to test that assumption, producing incomplete reassurance. Keep the loyalty and its eventual cost; let her do something with the suspicion.

**Finish / DNF / skim:** No DNF. I would read the crossing, notebook discovery and deck showdown closely. The likely skims are the second generator procedure and parts of Chapter 8's operational explanation.

**Heat:** Approximately **3/5**. The manual encounter in Chapter 5 and intercourse in Chapters 6 and 10 are on page and change the relationship. They are compact, not a sustained high-spice reading experience. This meets the lower end of the stated target.

**Book 2:** Yes. Russ's dry humor and Quist's bluntness appeal to me, and the ledger gives them unfinished business without withholding Beth and Dane's resolution.

## 2. THE DEVELOPMENTAL EDITOR

**Verdict:** A strong, distinctive romantic-suspense novella with an earned ending; its principal brief miss is mystery calibration, and its last act explains too much.

**Rating: 4/5.**

### Three biggest strengths

1. **Occupational knowledge generates structure.** The refrigeration unit, latch, bar, shore lane, binder, chain and buoy become usable information. Chapter 5 makes Dane trust Beth in an environment where her judgment governs survival. Chapter 9 repays those setups. Competence is a cause of events, not a trait asserted by the narrator.

2. **The midpoint, dark moment and intimacy have real functions.** The fire and first encounter overturn the hiding strategy around the functional midpoint; "We're done hiding" changes their method. The failed extraction then turns anticipated escape into injury. The notebook creates a substantive betrayal because personal disclosures have doubled as an undisclosed assessment. The three encounters mark different stages, and sexual consent does not erase the separate injury of concealment.

3. **Community loyalty makes betrayal expensive.** Tess's care and Ned's economic bargain are concrete. "Tess doesn't count" makes their shared exemption audible. Tess's warning restores some humanity without cancelling responsibility. The reconciliation assigns separate responsibility to both lovers, and its information-sharing rule has practical consequences. Christmas, repeated returns and Beth's movement toward the wheel make the ending credible.

### Three biggest problems

1. **Tess receives a much more complete case against her than the alternatives.** Debt and nighttime fueling create suspicion in Chapter 1. By Chapter 3, the private call, open log, booster, Arsenault and Ned's habit of telling Tess everything make a conspicuous information route. Other suspects get suggestive behavior; she gets motive, means, access and emphasis. Dane's earlier viewpoint also gives readers grounds to trust his protective purpose.

2. **The final approach loses pressure in procedural repetition.** Chapter 8 must handle Dane's night, Ned's disclosure, recognition, repair and planning. Its longest explanations render Pike's answer, negotiate the plan again, promise another call and lead into another rehearsal in Chapter 9. The binder lesson earns preservation because it is both action setup and relationship writing. Repeated permissions and alternative-closing explanations can be consolidated.

3. **The ferry's economic consequence is left open.** Ned justifies his silence with "No subsidy, no winter boat" in Chapter 8. Chapter 10 removes the dealer's contract, while the coda shows continuing freight and Beth's relief watches. If Ned exaggerated to justify himself, expose that. If his claim was accurate, give the reduced-service or replacement arrangement a concrete beat. The consequence should survive the arrests; it does not require a new subplot.

**When I identified the leak:** Tess was a serious candidate in **Chapter 1** and my probable answer by the end of **Chapter 3**. That is too early for the original concealed-leak brief. The fuel ledger and extraction arrangements reinforce it rather than reopening uncertainty.

**Change first:** Map who knows each location, what the reader knows and what Beth refuses to connect. In Round 1 I would revise the early evidence to make an alternative genuinely contestable, reducing repeated interpretive emphasis while retaining fair clues.

**Dark moment and ending:** Beth's Chapter 7 departure now has a practical plan: locked steel wheelhouse, stronger radio and a daylight appeal. It does not need unexplained flight to work. The complete romance ending is earned. The live procedural questions concern the case deadline, the supervisor's response to the operation and the compressed discipline/transfer timetable; these are matters for a knowledgeable reader, not verified findings of impossibility.

## 3. THE LINE EDITOR / AI-PROSE SPOTTER

**Verdict:** A sustained, concrete, commercially usable voice whose main limitation is overcontrol; selective subtraction would help more than generic polishing.

**Rating: 4/5.**

### Three biggest strengths

1. **Material language does narrative work.** "Neoprene told her nothing about a binder" belongs to this heroine and supplies evidence. The deck, diesel, rope, cold and machinery are strongest where they enable a decision. Preserve the working vocabulary and the physical sequences readers need to understand the payoffs.

2. **The best motifs change meaning.** The latch becomes an ordinary household sound; the door moves between vigilance and surrender; light moves between concealment, tactical control and a home Beth can occupy openly. The final request to bring the light combines work and partnership without explaining the combination. These repetitions are earned.

3. **Specific humor breaks the austerity.** Waterproof boots, the disappointing kit, Tess's pricing and the Christmas ham belong to the people speaking. The intimate scenes have distinct emotional functions and settings. The last encounter's privacy and audible pleasure complete the earlier vigilance effectively.

## Three biggest problems

1. **Emotional staging uses a narrow repertoire.** Hands move, remain open, stop short or withdraw; cups are set down; people inspect one another's silence. The literal words hand/hands occur **198 times** in the chapter text. That is a search aid, not 198 errors or evidence of machine authorship. The repeated emotional function matters more than the count.

2. **Explanation often follows sufficient evidence.** The clue appears, its interpretation follows, an earlier clue returns, then a conclusion is stated. The Tess chain across Chapters 7-8 is the clearest example. The long Pike relay also sounds organized to answer anticipated objections in sequence. Keep the necessities, but restore the feeling of people deciding under pressure.

3. **Polished wisdom is distributed too evenly.** Both leads and their narrators turn physical observations into balanced propositions. Dane can acquire the whole chapter's interpretive intelligence in one speech. Occasional plain uncertainty, an unfinished thought or an unglossed reaction would give the reader more room.

| Recurring device | Chapters | Editorial judgment |
|---|---|---|
| Negation followed by a corrected meaning | 1, 4, 5, 10 | Strong when it distinguishes physical evidence; predictable when it certifies an emotion already shown. |
| Action before conscious decision, followed by notice of that fact | 2, 3, 4 | Useful for instinct, conspicuous when repeatedly announced. |
| Hands, gaze and withheld speech carry every emotional register | 3-4, 8, 10 | Preserve skilled touch and decisive contact; thin redundant choreography around them. |
| Significant objects close scenes and chapters | 4, 5, 6, 7 | Pen, list, door and key earn some returns; vary smaller internal scene endings. |
| Reporting and disclosure recur around intimacy | 5, 6, 8, 10 | Retain agreements and consequences; shorten reminders that introduce no new choice. |

**Do the leads sound different?** Their dialogue is distinguishable: Beth is terse and materially exact; Dane qualifies and explains. Their close-third narration shares more cadence, inventories and concluding inferences. Differentiate through humor, association and uncertainty, rather than giving every Dane line another clause. Neither needs an accent or a catchphrase.

**Change first:** Condense Chapter 8's repair and Pike relays. Keep the admissions, disagreements, new boundary and decision; remove repeated proof of what the notebook, fish house and Ned's confession have already established. Apply that principle elsewhere selectively.

**Specific staging finding:** Chapter 9 places Beth on the deck before she takes the Icom "off the console," which is upstairs. Move the collection before the descent. The apparently repeated blackout is a labeled viewpoint rewind, not two actual outages. Chapter 6's pulse-as-truth conclusion should be recognizably Beth's belief, rather than categorical narrative authority.

**AI-prose judgment:** The disclosed origin is known from the brief; patterns cannot prove it. The prose reads as tightly controlled, not careless or interchangeable. Preserve its identity while reducing the sense that every reaction arrives pre-interpreted.

# 4. THE KDP MARKET STRATEGIST

**Verdict:** Advance toward a bounded pilot after targeted revision; this has a credible identity as a complete, steamy coastal romantic-suspense novella.

**Rating: 4/5 for commercial readiness.**

## Three biggest strengths

1. **The setting and heroine give the product a recognizable identity.** Beth's work matters from discovery to victory. Maine-island atmosphere, practical competence and reciprocal protection supply more useful positioning than a generic handsome-bodyguard promise.
2. **The heat belongs to the trust story.** Chapters 5, 6 and 10 deliver three different stages of intimacy. My subjective rating is **3/5**: clearly adult and explicit, with short scenes inside a suspense-led story. The original lower-end target is met. Exceptional-spice positioning would overstate the experience.
3. **The purchase is complete.** The immediate danger and this romance resolve. The ledger opens future business without requiring another purchase to finish Beth and Dane's love story. Approximately 34,600 words is a workable novella proposition when the length is made clear; padding it to increase subscription pages would undermine the product.

## Three biggest problems

1. **The opening sells maritime suspense sooner than personal attraction.** Dane enters in Chapter 2, and the first kiss waits until Chapter 4. That can work as a slow burn, but their first meeting spends considerable time on credentials, weather and transport. A brief reciprocal personal beat would help the sample communicate the particular couple's appeal. This is a conversion hypothesis, not measured sales evidence.
2. **The protector relationship becomes an administrative negotiation too often.** Disclosure and consequences matter. Repeated explanation across Chapters 5-10, particularly the long Pike quotation, competes with the feelings those decisions create. Compression would improve the emotional promise without removing accountability.
3. **The next case is clearer than the next romance.** Quist's winter invitation and Russ's reply have entertaining friction, but limited attraction. If they are the intended next couple, a restrained reciprocal beat or an actual next-book premise would strengthen the invitation. Their case alone does not guarantee continuation sales.

**Change first:** Strengthen the early couple presentation with one short personal exchange, funded by cuts to repeated logistics. Preserve the working-ferry opening. Do not automatically expand the sex scenes.

## Positioning, economics and launch

**Packaging:** Use adult, non-graphic coastal-suspense artwork with visible romantic intent, and identify both the novella length and open-door content in the retail description. "Steamy" is defensible at this intensity when the wider promise is restrained. "PG-13" should remain an internal visual shorthand, not a claim about the interior or an Amazon rating. No finished cover or retail blurb was supplied.

KDP's specific setup question concerns sexually explicit images or title/subtitle language. It does not define all on-page sexual prose as an affirmative answer to that narrower question. Answer against the actual assets, use accurate metadata and do not treat restrained packaging as a guarantee of platform treatment. [S1]

**Price:** Start the US ebook at **$2.99** and hold a baseline for roughly 30 days. An eligible 70% sale is about $2.09 before delivery and tax effects. The current Amazon.com 70% price band is $2.99-$12.99. A later $3.99 test is optional and needs comparable traffic to mean anything; these prices are recommendations, not ranking rules. [S2, S3]

**Subscription:** Consider one **90-day Select term** if its digital-exclusivity conditions fit the experiment. Current rules permit distribution through KDP and public libraries during that term. Amazon now calls Kindle Unlimited **Kindle+**; this report retains KU when referring to the user's original brief and reader role. [S4, S5]

Use the normalized page count assigned by KDP after upload and the realized monthly marketplace rate. Page income is the credited reading multiplied by that rate; no reliable payout follows from the manuscript word count alone. Track production costs, promotion, sales and credited pages. Aggregate page totals do not reveal individual completion. [S6]

**Categories:** Target Romantic Suspense first, then appropriate Contemporary Romance or Small Town Romance placements in the live marketplace picker. These are shelf recommendations, not verified selectable menu paths. KDP permits up to three relevant categories; do not force an inaccurate third or use clean/wholesome positioning. [S1]

**Cadence:** Consider Book 2 about **six to eight weeks later only if it is already fully edited, packaged and ready**. Otherwise evaluate this as a complete standalone pilot before promising a schedule. The one-clean/one-open-door experiment does not require committing to a full series. A cadence recommendation is not an empirically established algorithm threshold.

**AI disclosure:** Under KDP's definition this pipeline produced AI-generated text, including after substantial subsequent editing. Disclose it to KDP and assess generated artwork separately. Human direction does not convert generated prose into AI-assisted prose under that definition. [S7]

Neither the underlying research reports nor sales data were supplied. Two different clean and open-door titles can test two products; differences in plot, execution, cover, audience and launch prevent them from isolating the effect of heat.

## 5. THE SKEPTIC

**Verdict:** There is substantial craft here, but I would still hold the current text for a focused substantive revision before charging readers for it.

**Rating: 3.5/5.**

### Three biggest strengths

1. **Beth and Cutter are more distinctive than the trope bundle.** A capable local woman, restrained protector, dead-witness guilt and forced proximity are familiar ingredients. The refrigeration check, tidal judgment, freight subsidy and deck knowledge give this instance an identity. Beth genuinely drives survival and investigation.

2. **The sex changes something.** The crossing makes the first encounter reciprocal; the second temporarily releases vigilance; the third is a choice in her own home. Contraception, consent and occasional humor fit the adults involved. These scenes have more character than a standard inventory of attractive body parts.

3. **Tess has humanity worth betraying.** Soup, credit, parental history and affectionate touch establish her place in Beth's life. The warning and arrest preserve affection alongside responsibility. Ned's failure to reach toward her is a meaningful consequence. This strand is the book's richest emotional conflict.

### Three biggest problems

1. **The reader can wait too long for Beth to accept the indicated answer.** Chapters 3 and 6 give her access to the dangerous connections, and Chapter 7 explains the displacement clearly. That is psychologically coherent. It can still make intelligence feel selectively suspended while the reveal waits. The brief's mystery promise is stronger than the actual uncertainty.

2. **Institutional explanations repeatedly preserve the isolation.** The early assignment, storm, bridge, communications, failed landing, second system and delayed help all bring the story back to one impaired marshal with one witness. Chapter 2 introduces LifeFlight without an answer. Chapter 6 explains why that landing is

abandoned but leaves questions about the whole remaining rescue window. Chapter 8's authorization carries another large burden. These are practical plausibility concerns, not verified claims that service procedures are wrong.

3. **The repair is compressed relative to the breach.** The notebook reveals that personal disclosure has doubled as investigation while intimacy develops. Dane's acknowledgment and shared calls matter; the book deserves credit for them. Nevertheless, reconciliation, Christmas and a completed suspension plus desirable transfer arrive quickly. Some protector-romance readers may want more evidence of ordinary trust than an intense emergency bond. A personnel consequence does not automatically answer every intimate question.

**Change first:** Give Beth one reasonable attempt to test Tess before the extraction, receiving credible but incomplete reassurance. Replace a repeated observation rather than add another decorative suspect. The later collapse would create an investigative reversal alongside the emotional admission.

**Publication judgment:** Preserve the maritime specificity, practical intimacy and Tess's uncomfortable humanity. The strongest potential objections concern an obvious culprit, stretched rescue logic and convenient forgiveness. Those are reasons to edit the work, not reasons to penalize its disclosed AI origin. A pilot should test demand for its strengths after avoidable weaknesses are addressed.

# ROUND 2 - CROSS-TALK

All five retain their ratings. Several narrow their revision requirements after discussion.

## 1. Does early certainty about Tess require rebuilding the mystery?

**Developmental editor:** I would narrow my initial demand for rebalanced clues. Early identification misses the original brief but does not independently block publication. A proportionate check of Tess, producing incomplete reassurance, would strengthen Beth's judgment without rebuilding the suspect field.

**KU reader:** Knowing who may betray Beth can create dread. Repeated exemptions create impatience. I want less repetition more than another red herring.

**Market strategist:** Solving the leak does not resolve Dane's separate betrayal. Sell danger and compromised trust; test Beth's denial with actual readers.

**Skeptic:** I prefer an active check, but would accept leaner denial if readers remain invested. Early identification alone is not my release objection.

## 2. Is the final operation now justified, and does the blackout work?

**KU reader:** The new urgency motivated the operation on my first reading. The narrower concern is fair: Beth creates the condition permitting her descent, and her presence prevents Dane from firing.

**Developmental editor:** Keep the operation. Let an observable reversal require Beth's intervention, or establish why keeping the attacker illuminated becomes untenable.

**Line editor:** There is one blackout across overlapping viewpoints. The later call could revise Pike's earlier instructions. The issue is the chosen positions and movement trigger, not a proven permission breach.

**Market strategist and skeptic:** Both support a local causal correction preserving the climax. The skeptic retains broader rescue-plausibility questions for a knowledgeable reader; no verified agency-policy violation is asserted.

## 3. How much more romantic proof is necessary?

**Skeptic:** I narrow my demand for more romantic proof. Admissions, shared calls, intimacy after relief and Christmas provide substantial repair. More ordinary compatibility is a preference.

**KU reader:** I believe their future. Give the existing moments breathing room; I need no further punishment or costly demonstration.

**Line editor:** More assurances would aggravate Chapter 8's weakness. Compress interpretation; keep decisions and consequences.

**Developmental editor and market strategist:** Both oppose major romantic expansion. The market strategist retains early attraction and a stronger next-couple invitation as options. Finish the tactical and continuity work, compress selectively, then use human readers. Nobody requires heat padding.

# ROUND 3 - CHAIR'S SYNTHESIS

## Consensus rating and verdict

**Chair's consensus rating: 4/5, up from 3.5/5 for draft two.** The five independent ratings average **3.9/5**; the skeptic remains at 3.5. The chair's score is a rounded editorial judgment, not a forecast of customer ratings or sales.

This is a credible commercial-test manuscript with a distinctive heroine, an integrated romantic-suspense structure and a complete emotional ending. Claude has made the substantive course correction previously requested: Beth's departure now has a defensible plan, her concealment is admitted, the couple changes how it shares information, the operation has urgency before it is chosen, and Christmas becomes a concrete shared future. The remaining causal weakness is narrower: the deliberately engineered blackout and premature descent undermine the protective position before circumstances require it. Fix that trigger, resolve the remaining continuity and consequence gaps, and compress the explanations around the repairs. I recommend a bounded final edit followed by real readers, rather than another broad rewrite or more sexual content.

| Reviewer | Draft 2 | Draft 3 |
|---|---|---|
| KU reader | 3.5/5 | 4/5 |
| Developmental editor | 3.5/5 | 4/5 |
| Line editor | 3.5/5 | 4/5 |
| Market strategist | 3.5/5 | 4/5 |
| Skeptic | 3.5/5 | 3.5/5 |
| Chair | 3.5/5 | 4/5 |

## Did Claude address the previous recommendations?

**Yes, in conduct and structure, not merely in reassuring dialogue.** It would be inaccurate to carry the previous Chapter 7 criticism forward unchanged. Beth no longer disables the alarm, switches off her only communications and simply trusts Ned with her safety. Several previously unresolved implications do remain, and the new planning adds more explanation than the final book needs.

| Earlier concern | Status | Evidence in this version |
|---|---|---|
| Beth disables the alarm and flees to Ned | Substantially resolved | Chapter 7 leaves the alarm intact, keeps the radio listening, uses the shore route and chooses a locked wheelhouse plus a daylight mainland call. She explicitly considers Ned's lie and obtains a key; Chapter 8 gives her an escape route during their confrontation. |
| Dane misses the call without an adequate response | Resolved | He wakes at 11:15, reports at 11:20 and receives an explicit order to wait until first light. The night is replayed in Chapter 8 with a causal explanation. |

| Earlier concern | Status | Evidence in this version |
|---|---|---|
| Beth never admits the emergency-management omission | Resolved | She names what she knew and withheld: "That's mine. Yours is still yours." Dane acknowledges his own failure to ask about the information route. |
| The reconciliation has no practical change | Strengthened | Both agree to share names and calls. Subsequent joint calls demonstrate that change. It is not left as a promise in the apology scene. |
| The trap lacks urgency before the choice | Largely resolved | Fueling and preparations to sail, Tess's changed roll call and the risk of her being taken create an immediate problem before the plan. Limits on intervention and Pike's decision are now on page. The blackout/descent tactic remains a separate issue. |
| The ordinary future is insufficiently felt | Substantially resolved | Chapter 10's bus, ham, Santa hat and shift-cover conversation creates a particular invitation Beth accepts. The epilogue pays it off. |
| Cellar route and generator condition create gaps | Resolved | The cellar is planted in Chapter 3 and briefed in Chapter 8. The generator condition now concerns someone coming to ask about it, not simply its running after dark. |
| Repeated gestures and shared voice | Improved, incomplete | Several interpretive tags and repeated gestures are cut; Dane's speech is fuller. Recurrent choreography and similar close-third cadences remain, and Chapter 8 is more explanatory. |

The draft grew from **33,383 to 34,644 words**, a net addition of **1,261**, about **3.8%**, using the same whitespace count including headings and front matter. Chapter 6 is **238 words shorter**, about **7.1%**. Chapter 8 grows from **3,453 to 4,570 words**, about **32.3%**, measured within the chapter body. Most net expansion went to accountability and operational logic.

The proposed blanket addition of 300 words to each sex scene did not happen. Comparable passages are slightly shorter or unchanged. The front note still calls the book "steamy, open-door." The KU reader and market strategist both place the heat around 3/5; no reviewer requires more sex to make the current book work. I still prefer precise open-door positioning over exceptional-spice claims; retaining the modest word "steamy" is not a publication blocker.

The hand/hands count falls from **211 to 198** while the book grows. More significant than that number are actual deletions of explanations such as the former "He heard it. She watched him hear it." The remaining task is selective: preserve skilled touch and useful motifs, reduce interchangeable emotional choreography.

## Five changes with the highest return, ranked

1. **Change the trigger for Beth's blackout and descent.** Preserve the deck climax, but keep the safer opening arrangement until an observable reversal requires her intervention, or establish a specific reason its lighting advantage becomes untenable. **Backed by:** all five in cross-talk.

2. **Compress Chapter 8 and repeated interpretive prose.** Keep admissions, the shared-information agreement, operational constraints and the tactile rehearsal; consolidate Pike's relays and cut proof of conclusions already established. **Backed by:** all five, led by the line and developmental editors.

3. **Make Beth's early handling of Tess less repetitive and more active.** Prefer replacing one denial beat with a proportionate check that produces incomplete reassurance; at minimum, reduce repeated exemptions and let human readers judge whether the remaining denial creates dread or impatience. **Backed by:** all five on the problem; KU, developmental, line and skeptic favor the active check, while market treats it as optional.

4. **Reconcile knowledge, timing, orders and consequences.** Correct the specific items below, and account for what happens to winter ferry service after the contract that allegedly sustains it disappears. **Backed by:** developmental and line editors, with KU, market and skeptic support for consequential continuity work.

5. **Sharpen personal attraction in the sample and next-book invitation if needed.** A small reciprocal beat in Chapter 2 and a specific Quist/Russ attraction could strengthen the romantic promise; fund either from cuts and keep them optional rather than starting another expansion. **Backed by:** market strategist and KU reader; line editor favors more unforced emotional variety.

## The remaining tactical issue, precisely

The old objection was that the book offered safer alternatives but supplied insufficient reason to reject them. The new urgency and rescue objective answer that substantially. The remaining issue begins after that decision: Beth controls the floods, deliberately turns them off and descends before Dane is in trouble. He then explicitly cannot fire into darkness containing her. Their opening plan creates the disadvantage her exceptional deck knowledge must overcome.

Her knowledge explains how the rescue works. The scene still needs to establish why that risk is the appropriate response at that moment. One economical option is to keep her at the protected stairhead through initial contact, then let Dane's fall trigger her move onto the deck. The blackout itself also needs a clear purpose or a changed circumstance that makes it necessary. Another workable arrangement may exist; the criterion is visible cause and effect. Her agency, the stern-chain maneuver, the binder payoff and her rescue of Doucette should all survive.

Do not fix this by giving Pike another speech approving it. Also do not claim Beth violates a proven final order: the later joint call could have revised the earlier instructions. The concern is the plan's demonstrated advantage, not an invented permission breach.

## Continuity and logic findings

These distinguish direct staging problems from unresolved timing, implications and questions requiring judgment.

| Location | Finding | Required correction |
|---|---|---|
| Chapters 4-5 | Russ explicitly knows the Ashby location through the generator; nearby houses can hear it. Chapter 5 still says "Only Ned knew" and narrows the Ashby list to Ned and Dane. Chapter 8 now names Russ but does not repair that earlier deduction. | Include Russ and the known audible access in the Chapter 5 location audit, or distinguish the narrower question being asked. |
| Chapters 8-10 | Pike says first light is the earliest mainland arrival; Chapter 9 says relief will come the first hour the sea allows and identifies that as first light. Chapter 10 opens with arrival at noon. The added drive for two deputies does not specify what causes the gap. | Align arrival and departure times, retime the arrival, or establish the actual delay. This is an unexplained gap, not proof a noon arrival is physically impossible. |
| Chapter 10 | The noon instruction is to cross on the "first boat." Marine Patrol makes further trips, yet Dane stays overnight for Sunday's ferry. | Specify the first ferry or an explicit revised transport instruction, so his compliance and the night at home agree. |

| Location | Finding | Required correction |
|---|---|---|
| Chapter 9 | Beth descends, places her boots inside the deckhouse door and steps onto the car deck before taking the Icom "off the console," established upstairs. | Collect the radio before descending. |
| Chapters 8 and 10 | Ned says loss of the dealer's subsidy means no winter boat. The contract disappears, but continuing service and Beth's relief watches are presented without the financial consequence. | Show a reduced or replacement arrangement, or establish that Ned's categorical claim was self-justification. A brief concrete beat is enough. |

**Additional clarifications:** The Chapter 8 inference that Tess has until dark sits beside a 5:30 p.m. call and an 11 p.m. attack. Since this is a prediction rather than a fixed deadline, it is not a proven contradiction; align the expected departure window so the urgency holds. Confirm Beth's intended XtraTuf model or alternate footwear if the lacing references are retained. Frame the Chapter 6 pulse-based certainty as her belief. These are smaller than the first four corrections above.

**Do not re-report repaired or nonexistent errors.** The alarm is no longer disabled; the missed nightly call has been removed; the tide walk now follows a coherent progression from the 10:05 low through the rising water; the cellar route is planted; the third encounter remains in Chapter 10. The blackout is shown twice across a viewpoint overlap but happens once. The Friday-to-Sunday ten-day count and Monday appointment work. The main romance has a happy ending.

## Specialist assumptions that still deserve a targeted check

Chapter 2's LifeFlight suggestion receives no direct answer. The initial 9:15 ferry decision assumes an open mainland terminal is the waiting option. After the Chapter 6 gunfire, the explanation closes that landing more clearly than it closes all possible assistance. A knowledgeable reader should examine those restrictions as one chain, along with the distinction between a daylight approach and the new nighttime ledge-field constraint. This is a request to make the fictional mission's limits convincing, not a claim that every real vessel must be able to make it.

The grand-jury deadline also needs a case-specific explanation. Federal Rule 5.1 provides a preliminary-hearing timetable, allows extensions under specified conditions and continues proceedings when probable cause is found. A hearing does not itself establish that a seized-drug prosecution falls apart. Clarify why Beth's particular evidence and this date are indispensable. [S8]

Have the same relevant professional review the reporting/assessment arrangement, likely response to the operation, discipline and transfer timeline, and Quist's confident licensing assurances. Distinguish a useful plausibility adjustment from a demand to turn a novella into a procedural manual. The story does not need pages of additional bureaucracy.

## Publication decision and human work

**Publishable after a bounded final revision. Ready for human beta readers now. Not yet the exact file I would upload to KDP.** The four-star judgment recognizes a successful reading experience; it does not mean there are no consequential fixes left.

The human's remaining work is concrete:

1. **Approve the tactical solution and the scope.** Resolve the blackout/descent trigger, compress the repetitive briefings and reconcile the listed facts. Keep the third encounter and the Christmas conversation. Do not commission another general rewrite or a uniform heat expansion.

2. **Choose the mystery promise deliberately.** I recommend accepting this as suspense about a painful betrayal, with a cleaner, more active treatment of denial. That relaxes the original "not obvious early" requirement. If a concealed culprit remains mandatory, a genuinely rebalanced evidence structure would still be needed; changing the description does not satisfy the old brief.

3. **Use actual readers and targeted expertise.** Ask a small group of open-door romantic-suspense readers where they first suspect Tess, whether they remain with Beth through Chapter 6, whether the Chapter 7 plan and final deck movement make sense, whether the reconciliation lands, and whether they want the next couple. Obtain the focused federal/marine check above. One useful fresh read matters more now than another decimal increase from simulated reviewers.

4. **Approve the complete final ebook and product.** Read the revised sequence in context and proof the reading file, scene breaks and navigation. Replace the pen-name placeholder, inspect the actual cover and blurb, make the AI-generated disclosure and decide whether Select's terms fit the test. No packaging has yet been reviewed here. [S4, S7]

5. **Run a bounded commercial test.** Define a spend cap and assess royalties, costs, page consumption and demand for another title. Do not promise rapid continuation without finished inventory. Neither an AI panel score nor a category badge establishes profitability.

The stopping condition is a clear final tactical sequence, a consistent knowledge/time record and human readers who remain invested in Beth and the couple. Additional personal banter, a more elusive culprit or a higher heat level are not universal release conditions.

## What this draft says about the pipeline

The third draft is stronger evidence for the pipeline than the second. Chapter 7 demonstrates an ability to change behavior and propagate the change: leaving the alarm intact leads to Dane's earlier waking, the scheduled call, an explicit instruction and a rewritten night. The shore route alters the tide passage. The wheelhouse objective changes how Beth treats Ned. Those are connected revisions, not isolated apologies to a critic.

The reciprocal admission also causes subsequent information-sharing, and the Christmas invitation receives a specific epilogue payoff. The book has retained its best identity while taking criticism. Its occupational detail, tactile prose and uncomfortable community loyalty give it more individuality than a generic trope assembly.

The weakest part remains judging when an explanation is sufficient and whether every consequence has been followed. The revised operation adds genuine urgency, but also a long official relay; the permission to leave safety still needs practical justification. The first-light relief language does not align cleanly with noon, and the late acknowledgment of Russ does not rewrite the earlier suspect list. The pipeline can still mark a concern addressed because a later paragraph mentions it, while earlier implications remain active.

For future books, add one whole-book audit of changed promises, knowledge, deadlines, rejected alternatives and physical movement. Pair it with a subtraction pass that asks which explanations merely certify what readers already understand. Track reader knowledge separately from the protagonist's knowledge. Use human genre readers for emotional confidence and product expectations, where another model's assurance is least informative.

This version supports the conclusion that the pipeline can produce a coherent, distinctive novella worth testing commercially and can make substantive revisions. It does not establish sales, profitability or a heat-market winner. The next evidence should come from real readers and a controlled spending decision, rather than another round of automatic expansion.

# SOURCE NOTES

Editorial source: the supplied ten-days-out-third-draft.md, read locally in full. Comparison: the retained complete second draft and its delivered panel report, checked after the fresh independent readings. Chapter references and brief quotations identify manuscript evidence. Counts use whitespace splitting and include front matter/headings where stated; chapter-body comparisons exclude chapter-title lines. Counts are not KENP or indicators of AI authorship. Platform and procedural sources were checked on 27 October 2026 in the user's timezone. Recommendations are distinguished from platform rules.

[S1] Amazon KDP, Metadata Guidelines for Books. Primary-audience question, accurate metadata and up to three categories. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G201097560

[S2] Amazon KDP, eBook List Price Requirements. Current Amazon.com 70% price band. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200634560

[S3] Amazon KDP, eBook Royalties. Eligible territories, tax and delivery effects. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200644210

[S4] Amazon KDP, KDP Select Enrollment. Ninety-day term and current distribution conditions. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/GD9PMU58BV24QFZ7

[S5] Amazon, Kindle+ subscription questions and answers. Update dated 22 October 2026 records the Kindle Unlimited rename. https://www.aboutamazon.com/news/devices/what-is-kindle-plus

[S6] Amazon KDP, Kindle Edition Normalized Page. Standardized page calculation and monthly marketplace rate. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G5HHMLVVEW48MQYW

[S7] Amazon KDP, Content Guidelines. AI-generated definition and disclosure, including substantially edited generated content. https://kdp.amazon.com/en_US/help/topic/G200672390

[S8] U.S. Courts, Federal Rules of Criminal Procedure, Rule 5.1, edition amended through 1 December 2025, printed 2026, printed pages 8-9. https://www.uscourts.gov/sites/default/files/document/federal-rules-of-criminal-procedure.pdf